



Shamsah Sonawalla

GUEST COLUMN

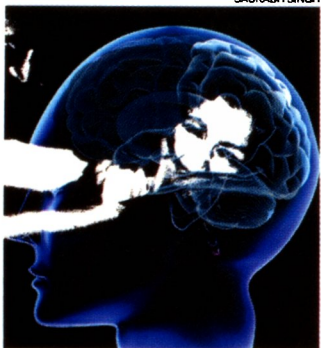
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Make Deterrence Work

Women must also learn self-defence and be observant

Rape is primarily an act of violence. It has less to do with sex and more to do with domination, power and control. There are several factors that drive men to commit such acts. The most important factor is deep-seated aggression. Traditionally, it is firmly fixed in the psyche of people, that men are supposed to be "aggressive and dominating" and women, "passive and submissive." While this is changing, in some individuals, this mode of thinking still prevails. Other factors include repeated exposure to violence, either personal or via the media and prior sexual abuse. Alcohol and drugs are key factors as well. A combination of substance abuse and raging hormones can wreak havoc. Men lose inhibition and control and become far more aggressive under the influence of alcohol and drugs, which gives them the courage to commit such crimes. The use of drugs affects the perpetrator as well the victim, as in some date rapes where the men use alcohol and drugs to make the woman unconscious.

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However, what may be important to note is the frequency of such crimes committed by seemingly normal people. According to some studies, in up to 92 per cent cases, the act is committed by men known to the women and an equal number occur in familiar surroundings. An important change in recent times is the greater reporting of rape unlike in the past, when the "don't ask, don't tell" policy prevailed. As a society, we need to work towards educating women at every level, encouraging them to be observant and learn self-defence. We also need to educate men in alternative modes of relating

to women, rather than just adopting an aggressive attitude. The media too plays a crucial role. Currently, the media is intensely involved in reporting and dissecting such incidents, and while it can sometimes impact the psyche of the victim negatively, the bright side is that the intense public pressure and the strict enforcement of laws can work as a deterrent for potential perpetrators.

However, what gets little or no attention is the devastating psychological aftermath of rape, which can have far-reaching, sometimes life-long, consequences. The woman can go through acute stress disorder immediately after the incident, which can last for a few weeks, during which she may be in a state of shock, numbness and denial, and may experience intense anxiety. She may then experience guilt, a feeling that somehow she brought it on herself. She may feel violated, humiliated and angry. A significant number of women experience physical and mental illnesses. Most common is post traumatic stress disorder, which occurs in about 30 per cent of women, and includes intense anxiety, disturbed sleep, recurring nightmares and flashbacks. This often requires intense psychotherapy and often, medication. For a long time,

in his car from south Mumbai. He took her to the mill compound in suburban Worli, where he allegedly raped her. Kasliwal was granted bail by the Bombay High Court after he spent a month in jail. The verdict is still pending even as the victim has testified in court. In the first set of DNA reports submitted by the Forensic Science Laboratory, Kalina, in Mumbai, Kasliwal tested negative. However, when the semen samples were sent for DNA fingerprinting and diagnostics to the Centre for DNA Fingerprinting and Diagnostics, Hyderabad, Kasliwal tested positive for rape. "There is no fear of law," says Shetty, "because even the tiny percentage of cases that get reported are not dealt with properly."

Take the rape and murder of a bright young Hewlett Packard staffer Pratibha Srikant Murthy in Bangalore. There is no closure for her even three years on though the case is in a fast track court. And this, as Pramila Nesargi, former chairperson of the Karnataka State Women's Commission, says is just the edge of the wedge. "For every rape victim whose case hits the spotlight, there are lots of women who are silent sufferers. Many of them don't want to go public because of the stigma attached." Worryingly, there appears to be no stigma in being a rapist. In conversation with 39 Tihar inmates who were literate, articulate, belonged to the middle-class families, and convicted for rape, Swanchetan Director Rajat Mitra discovered that most of them "got a high just talk-